TEXORA · LECTURE SHEET

Trimmings

Buttons, zips, interlinings, elastic, fasteners, labels and decorative trims: their specification systems (lignes, zip sizes, fusing windows), consumption arithmetic and incoming quality control.

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1. Trims: everything that is not the shell fabric

Trimmings (trims) are all the materials of a garment other than its main fabric: functional items (buttons, zips, thread, elastic, interlining), decorative items (lace, braid, sequins, embroidery), and information items (labels, tags, packaging). Trims commonly account for a modest share of garment cost but a large share of garment *problems*: a late or wrong trim stops a line as completely as missing fabric, and a failed trim (a zip that splits, a button that cracks in washing) fails the whole garment in the customer's hands. Trim management is therefore a technology subject, not a purchasing footnote.

2. The principal trim families

FAMILY	MAIN TYPES AND SPECIFICATION POINTS
Buttons	Materials: polyester resin, nylon, metal, shell, corozo, wood, horn. Types: sew-through (2/4-hole) and shank. Size in **lignes (L)**: 1 ligne = 0.635 mm, so a 24L button = 24 × 0.635 = 15.2 mm. Specify diameter, thickness, hole pattern, colour, wash/ironing resistance.
Zips (slide fasteners)	Coil (spiral), moulded-tooth and metal-tooth; closed-end, open-end (separating) and two-way. Size by chain width (#3, #5, #8). Specify length, tape colour, slider type (auto-lock for trouser flies), strength class.
Interlinings	Fusible (resin-coated: dot/printed coatings of PA, PES, EVA) and sew-in; woven, knit and nonwoven bases. Specified by weight, resin type, fusing conditions and hand required — collars, cuffs, waistbands, fronts.
Elastic	Woven, knitted and braided; rubber or elastane core. Specify width, stretch and recovery, and shrinkage so waistbands fit after washing.
Hook-and-loop, snaps, rivets,	Metal or plastic press fasteners; setting dies and pressure are part of the specification, with pull-strength testing on production.

eyelets	
Shoulder pads, tapes, cords	Foam or layered pads; stay tapes and mobilon (clear elastic) tape for shoulder seams of knits; drawcords with aglets and cord locks.
Labels and packaging	Main label (woven/printed), size label, care label (fibre content + care symbols required by destination law), price/hang tags, polybags, cartons. Care-label accuracy is a legal matter in most export markets.
Decorative trims	Lace, braid, ribbons, embroidery (thread and placement spec), sequins/beads (with safety testing for children's wear), heat-transfer and printed motifs, reflective tapes for workwear/sportswear.

3. Interlining and fusing: the trim with process physics

Fusing bonds a resin-coated interlining to the shell under controlled **temperature, pressure and time** — the three variables of every fusing press, set from the resin's melt range (commonly press conditions around 140–160 °C, 10–20 s, with pressure per the maker's chart). Two failure modes define the topic: **strike-through** (resin penetrates to the face of a light fabric, showing as shine or spots) and **strike-back** (resin soaks into the interlining instead of bonding), plus delamination and bubbling after washing when conditions or compatibility are wrong. Every new fabric–interlining pair is test-fused and peel-tested before bulk, and the fusing conditions are recorded on the style's setting sheet like any machine setting.

4. Trim consumption and ordering: a worked example

Example — buttons for a shirt order. A shirt takes 7 front buttons + 2 cuff + 1 spare sewn in = 10 buttons; order quantity 50,000 shirts = 500,000 buttons. Add process and rejection allowance of 3%: 515,000 buttons. Buttons are traded per gross (144): 515,000 ÷ 144 = 3,576.4, so **3,577 gross** are ordered, shade-checked against the approved trim card on arrival. The same per-garment × order × (1 + allowance) pattern, with each trim's own packing unit (cones, metres, gross, pairs), is the whole of trim ordering — errors here are arithmetic, and they stop lines.

5. Trim quality control

Incoming trims are checked against the **approved trim card** (the buyer's signed reference set): shade under standard light, dimensions (button ligne gauge, zip length and function, elastic stretch/recovery), and performance spot-tests (zip open–close cycles, snap pull, fusing peel, button wash test). Trims are stored by style in the trims store, issued against the bill of materials, and reconciled at order close — leftover buyer-supplied trims are accounted back, a compliance point in many factories.

Glossary

TERM	MEANING
Ligne (L)	Button size unit: 1 ligne = 0.635 mm of diameter.
Trim card	The buyer-approved reference set of all trims for a style, against which deliveries are checked.
Strike-through	Fusing fault: resin penetrating to the fabric face, visible as shine or marking.
Bill of materials (BOM)	The complete list, with quantities, of fabric and trims consumed by one garment.
Gross	A trade quantity of 144 pieces.

Key points and summary

- Trims are few in cost but decisive in failure: specify, test and reconcile them like fabric.
- Buttons are sized in lignes (24L = 15.2 mm); zips by chain size and length; interlinings by base, resin and fusing window.
- Fusing is controlled by temperature, pressure and time, and proven by peel tests on every new fabric pair.
- Trim quantity = per-garment use × order quantity × (1 + allowance), converted into the trim's trading unit.

Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. Convert to millimetres: (a) an 18L shirt button, (b) a 32L coat button.
2. An order of 12,000 trousers needs 1 zip each; allowance 2%. Zips come in bundles of 100. How many bundles?
3. Name the three fusing variables and the two strike faults, and state the test that must precede bulk fusing of a new fabric–interlining pair.
4. Why is the care label classed as a legal item rather than a decorative trim?

Answer key

1. (a) 18 × 0.635 = 11.4 mm. (b) 32 × 0.635 = 20.3 mm.
2. 12,000 × 1.02 = 12,240 zips ÷ 100 = 122.4, so 123 bundles.

3. Temperature, pressure and time. Strike-through (resin reaches the face) and strike-back (resin soaks into the interlining, weakening the bond). A test fusing followed by a peel-strength test (and a wash check where relevant) must pass first.
4. Because destination-market law requires accurate fibre-content and care information; a wrong care label can force relabelling, fines or rejection of the shipment — consequences no decorative trim carries.
